

In the shadow of a great man

An autobiography by Paige Willowbranch

"I am the child of a child of a child of a very great man. A man who will outlive me and outlived every single person in my family."

"Where a fruit falls is not where it sets its seeds" - Kenlien Birch in *Traveling the tables of the coast*

Many of you will recognize my surname before anything else. I'd like to get this over with. I am the third generation from the great XXX Willowbranch. Known for the Willowbranch publishing and scribing company, the world selling "Spikewreath" novels along with many many articles on the arcane, occult and the divine.

This has brought me no pleasure from the day of my birth, where my parents still trying to live up to their grandsires aspirations named me Paige, yes just like a page of a book. Well it's not **that** cruel it's also my maternal grandmothers middle name.

I've been groomed, pestered and in later years blackmailed into continuing our legacy. Oh, the horror to have a Willowbranch who doesn't write. This frustrates me to my very core, since to my own dismay I actually do like to write. Although to my parents and grandsires dismay I am frankly not that good at it.

Despite years and years of tutors, spiritual practices, arcane research and more activities to count I have nothing to write or say. Compared to my learned, travelled and prodigy of a grandsire I have not done anything yet, I've saved no maidens, I've slain no dragons.

"To soar is every bird's destiny" - Syf Silverwind in *Why winds cry*

Since this book will only be read and published post mortem, and the fact it evaporates into smoke after it leaves my person I have no fear to confess to this.

My mediocre success as an author is not even due to my own talent. If you are a fan of my work, I highly advice you to seek arcane health services. While scrounging around my grandsires libraries I found a pre calamity book, within hid a force I have not identified as of yet.

It has released any innate block I've experienced from learning druidic, arcane or divine magic though I am still an apprentice of each. In payment for this the entity seemed to have imbued my books with a low effective mimetic magic. This causes those with little connection to the world to obsess over the work and seek out more of it. Anyone with some sort of semblance of force of will seems to be unaffected.

"A man's measure is simple his height" - Dion Thunderbreaker in *Mountain Lords*

Very recently a man of great repute sailed north to chart and retake the lost continent of Farlorret. While my grandsire is particularly silent about the life before the calamities I intend to uncover them on my own.

My boat departs in three days, and I've pulled every copper from producing my previous books to fund this expedition. I will not return home before a discovery to overshadow my legacy has been unearthed.

As I arrived a well-dressed man greeted me at the guild. *Gustave Alleghieri*, a known name, the Guild master and a good contact. He accepted my recommendation though doubted by field experience and rudely suggested I ought to stay back to commit my self to filing reports.

I was then escorted to my room with a welcome gift of three health potions, I suppose that passes for health insurance out here. The room is not large, it contains a bed, a table with two chairs and an end table. I shudder to ask where a bath can be procured.

A few days have gone by, and no quests have been posted for someone of my new rank. "Too dangerous for someone unproven" they claim. I hate the idea of lounging, but I'll defer to my betters I suppose. In the meantime I've posted about my experience as a scholar for hire, even using my knowledge of publishing to produce high quality books and reports.

"Raised in the dark, safety in our mountain home" - Dew Windrose in *Tales of home*

I met a strange dwarf in the markets carrying a gigantic metal mirror up to a small chapel. About the size of the chapel to the Seldarine back at the estate but dedicated to the human aspect of Hanali, The Lady of Love Sune.

The dwarf introduced herself as *Kimmy*, devout follower of *Sune*. A fellow jack of all trades though in her case it seems to be limited to clerical duties. Her family seemed to have had differing expectation than her current ecclesiastical work. I surely can relate to that...

She was inclined to my plight that brought me here though I did not mention the source of my recent excellence. I ought to return her kindness once I've returned from my first expedition to tell her my exploits. Her kindness is something I've not felt in many years...

Gustave finally pulled through, acquiring a contract for a survey of the north-west plateau. I will use my somewhat adequate study of cartography I ought to be able to contribute well enough to earn my recognition.

I was paired up with a meek looking drow named "Nyx" and a utilitarian looking woman called "Foy". The propensity for adventurers to have single syllable names is beyond me.

The drow proclaimed himself a ranger, while leading us through every thorn bush this side of the continent and despite claiming he grew up in the mountains could not climb further than 20ft before falling. Ms Foy on the other hand turned out to be a much better climber and made light work of it.

After ascending the plateau we were met with the remains of a dwarf clutching a lockbox. Seeing the face of my first acquaintance since setting foot on the continent flash, I sought to give the body a proper burial. While trying to ascertain if any affiliation could be found on his person, A steel

pendant of dwarven cultural heritage. Inscribed on it was "So that you will never be away from home" with steel parts to symbolise home.

After a quick funeral service, we carried on. We sighted an earth elemental the size of a small house in the distant north, it was to our best guess rearranging the cliffs to suit as a nest.

Scouting further west before we were intercepted by starving Hyenas. The emaciated beasts did not hesitate to lunge even though we were armed. Mr Nyx was knocked out and almost dragged away if Ms Foy was not a moment faster than the reaper.

A better topographic map could be made from one of the mountain heights but the roving earth elementals and inadequate climbing gear made us retreat as for now.

During our last night on the plateau I was visited by what I can only assume is freshly spawned elementals in the form of swirling pebbles. I managed to sooth them with my magic and once dawn rose they vanished. A few of them into my backpack it turned out once we had declined rock walls again. I stashed these now dormant elementals in my inn room

He who lurks underneath the surface of pleasantries always stays the same - Masked stranger in *Cloaked Dagger: A winters bite*

Another quest with Mr Nyx. It seems we are destined to journey together, this time to find...blue camels. Gustave ensured me it was no jest, and I am inclined to believe him.

After arriving just east of town to find a caravan of blue people, with blue camels as advertised. Waiting for us was a tall, muscular woman with a strong wide nose and floppy ears on a bed of indigo curled hair. She wore armour polished to a shine and spoke with a cadence similar a circle matron. Her name is "Enira" and was our companion for the quest.

We conversed with the caravaners and their camels which led us over to a road. After walking along it scanning the edges for camel tracks leading off it, we met a merchant of a similar descent as the caravaners. He was selling pets and claimed to only help paying customers. With the lingering embers of the magic helping me to converse with the camels the pets being sold were screaming in a cacophony with one of them crying out "We were once people!"

While trying to disable the man's cart it bled and turned out to be a tame Mimic. After a bloody fight, where Mr Nyx once again was knocked unconscious, this time almost dragged away to be made into a pet instead of a meal. We brought the mimic to heel and the owner was slain by Mr Nyx, perhaps some sort of investment into seances would be useful.

We quickly found the run away camel being harrassed by sentient plants close by. The plants were very compliant with Ms Enira's exchange of purified water in exchange of letting the camel go.

We brought the camel back to caravan, leaving Enira to hold up her end of the bargain and the pets back to Embergate and Gustave ensured us that a solution would be looked into.